Chapter Sixty-Six

After the Famine

Between 1318 and 1330,
Philip V is troubled by shepherds and lepers,
and the Capetian dynasty gives way to the Valois,
while Edward II is defeated by his wife and her lover
and comes to an uncertain end

In 1318, for the fifth year in a row, Philip V of France promised to go on crusade.

The oath had become part of the regular rhetoric of French kings, an orthodox sign of commitment to the Christian cause. Philip had "taken the cross" for the first time in 1313, along with his father and brother; and his promise to march east and fight against the Muslims—whether Arab, Ottoman, or Mamluk—had been renewed every year.

And perhaps Philip V did intend to go on crusade, some year when France was prosperous and at peace, his officials in line, his people content and unlikely to rebel. But 1318 was not that year. Nor, as it turned out, was 1319;